

THE CURSE OF THE FIVE BLAMES

When teams first adopt Five Whys as a problem-solving tool, they encounter some common pitfalls. We need systems like Five Whys to overcome our psychological limitations because we tend to overreact to what's happening in the moment. We also tend to get frustrated if things happen that we did not anticipate.

When the Five Whys approach goes awry, I call it the Five Blames. Instead of asking why repeatedly in an attempt to understand what went wrong, frustrated teammates start pointing fingers at each other, trying to decide who is at fault. Instead of using the Five Whys to find and fix problems, managers and employees can fall into the trap of using the Five Blames as a means for venting their frustrations and calling out colleagues for systemic failures. Although it's human nature to assume that when we see a mistake, it's due to defects in someone else's department, knowledge, or character, the goal of the Five Whys is to help us see the objective truth that chronic problems are caused by bad process, not bad people, and remedy them accordingly.

I recommend several tactics for escaping the Five Blames. The first is to make sure that everyone affected by the problem is in the room during the analysis of the root cause. The meeting should include anyone who discovered or diagnosed the problem, including customer service representatives who fielded the calls, if possible. It should include anyone who tried to fix the symptom as well as anyone who worked on the subsystems or features involved. If the problem was escalated to senior management, the decision makers who were involved in the escalation should be present as well.

This may make for a crowded room, but it's essential. In my experience, whoever is left out of the discussion ends up being the target for blame. This is just as damaging whether the scapegoat is a junior employee or the CEO. When it's a junior employee, it's all too easy to believe that that person is replaceable. If the CEO is not present, it's all too easy to assume that his or her behavior is unchangeable. Neither presumption is usually correct.